

FAST FORWARD

◀ REWIND



A NEW INDIA: Signing the Planning Commission report.
From right: Nehru, G.L. Nanda and R.K. Patil

Courtesy Nehru Memorial Museum and Library

Agriculture was the highest priority for the first Five Year Plan that was expected to “bring the whole of India—agricultural, industrial, social and economic—into one framework of thinking”. With a total expenditure of Rs 2,069 crore, the Plan allotted 44.6 per cent of it to agriculture, including irrigation and power projects. It was during this Plan—from 1951-1956—that the mega dam projects of Bhakra-Nangal, Hirakud and Mettur dam were initiated. The Plan allocated Rs 173 crore to industry. A little over four-fifths of the Rs 497 crore earmarked for the development of transport and communications was set aside for railways. By the end of the Plan, in 1956, five Indian Institutes of Technology were also started.

◀ DID YOU KNOW

Japan was barred from the 1948 Olympic Games but was allowed to compete in the inaugural Asian Games held in Delhi.

A MATTER OF RELIGION

When President Rajendra Prasad inaugurated the newly restored Somnath Temple in Gujarat, Jawaharlal Nehru was horrified and asked him to reconsider. When he did not, it added to the growing belief among critics that the Congress under P.D. Tandon had become deeply conservative.

FIRST CUT

- The first Indian Institute of Technology was built on the site of a former British prison camp in Kharagpur, West Bengal.
- The villagers of Chini in Himachal Pradesh became the first Indians to cast votes in India's first general elections that began in 1951.